Emily Zohar

PhD Candidate, Experimental Psychology | Behavioural Science Researcher

Toronto, ON | emily.zohar@mail.utoronto.ca | University of Toronto | Work Authorization: Canada & United States

PROFILE

PhD Candidate in experimental psychology specializing in human motivation, effort, and social norms, with peer-reviewed publications, awarded fellowship funding, and hands-on consulting experience applying behavioural science to real-world challenges. Experienced translating evidence to non-specialist audiences across academic, media, and client-facing contexts. Seeking to apply behavioural science practice to a public-interest consulting environment.

EDUCATION

PhD, Experimental Psychology *Sep 2023 – Present*

University of Toronto | Supervisor: Dr. Michael Inzlicht

- Faculty of Arts & Science Top (FAST) Doctoral Fellowship recipient ($25,000/year, 2023–2027).
- Research focus: effort, motivation, social norms, and behaviour change.

BSc (Hons. with Distinction), Psychology *Sep 2021 – Apr 2023*

Queen's University | Concentration: Social & Personality Psychology | Minor: Mathematics

- Dean's Honour List throughout degree (2019–2023).
- Independent research project on the Jumping-to-Conclusions Fishing Task.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

PhD Student — Work and Play Lab *Sep 2023 – Present*

University of Toronto | Supervisor: Dr. Michael Inzlicht

- Design and execute controlled experiments examining effort, motivation, and social norms.
- Conduct statistical analyses and authored peer-reviewed publications disseminated in leading psychology journals and covered by major science media outlets.
- Investigate how effort norms propagate within social groups and shape individual exertion
- Exploring the impact of AI on work and relationships, research pertinent to the future of work.

Affiliated Student — Bernhardt-Walther Lab *May 2025 – Present*

University of Toronto | Supervisor: Dr. Dirk B. Walther

- Conducting research on aesthetic perception and environmental psychology with implications for workspace policy and public environment design.

Directed Lab Student — MaSC Lab & FAB Lab *Sep 2022 – Apr 2023*

Queen's University | Supervisors: Dr. Jill Jacobson, Dr. Lee Fabrigar

- Designed and ran independent research project examining the convergent and discriminant validity of the Jumping-to-Conclusions Fishing Task.

CONSULTING & APPLIED EXPERIENCE

Research Intern — BEworks *May 2022 – May 2023*

Toronto, ON | Applied Behavioural Science Consultancy

- Conducted reviews and literature analyses for consulting teams across private and public sector client engagements.
- Supported senior strategists and associates on think tanks and client projects, gaining early exposure to translating behavioural science evidence into practical recommendations.

- Designed and delivered MURAL-based digital workshops for internal and external clients; constructed and deployed surveys on Qualtrics.
- Independently developed an Information Presentation Best Practices resource subsequently adopted organization-wide and considered for external commercialization.

Intern — Babbly *Jun 2020 – Jan 2021*

Toronto, ON

- Contributed to UX testing and product feedback for a mobile app grounded in childhood behavioural and linguistic development psychology.
- Collaborated with the executive team on marketing strategy and product launch planning.

PUBLICATIONS

Zohar, E., Bloom, P., & Inzlicht, M. (2026). Against frictionless AI. *Communications Psychology, 4(1),* Article 39. https://doi.org/10.1038/s44271-026-00402-1

→ *Examines the long term implications of AI reducing effort and friction in work and relationships.*

Zohar, E., & Inzlicht, M. (2026). Effort norms encourage more exertion but not less. *Journal of Experimental Psychology. General, 155(4),* 1103–1119. https://doi.org/10.1037/xge0001904

→ *UTSC Psychology Best Paper Award 2026. Demonstrates effort contagion with both high and low effort norms increasing effort willingness.*

Zohar, E., Walther, D. B. (2026). Pretty Useless? Aesthetic Appeal of Office Images Is Associated With Anticipated but Not Objective Productivity. *Journal of Environmental Psychology, 112*, Article 103043. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jenvp.2026.103043

→ *Explores the effect of an offices visual appeal on predicted and actual productivity.*

Peetz, J., LeBlanc, C., Wells, T., **Zohar, E.**, & Sidhu, D. M. (2025). On top of the hour: Preference for scheduling and starting tasks at the beginning of the hour. Canadian Journal of Experimental P sychology/Revue canadienne de psychologie expérimentale, 80(2), 81–88. https://doi.org/10.1037/cep0000382

→ *CPA Best Article Award 2025. Finding that individuals prefer to schedule tasks on the hour.*

AWARDS & FELLOWSHIPS

FAST Doctoral Fellowship — University of Toronto — $25,000/year *2023–2027*

UTSC (University of Toronto Scarborough) Psychology Best Paper Award — Effort norms encourage more exertion but not less — $250 *2026*

CPA (Canadian Psychology Association) Best Article Award (CJEP/RCPE) — On top of the hour: Preference for scheduling and starting tasks at the beginning of the hour. *2025*

Dean's Honour List — Queen's University *2019–2023*

MEDIA COVERAGE

Zohar, E., & Inzlicht, M. (2026). Is laziness contagious. *SPSP Character and Context Blog*. https://spsp.org/news/character-and-context-blog/zohar-inzlicht-laziness-effort-contagion

Ramirez, V. B. (2026). What Happens If AI Makes Things Too Easy for Us? *IEEE Spectrum*. https://spectrum.ieee.org/frictionless-ai-psychology

Pereira, M. (2026) Are workers more productive in beautiful spaces? *University of Toronto Faculty of Arts & Science*. https://www.artsci.utoronto.ca/news/are-workers-more-productive-beautiful-spaces

Gupta, S. (2026) AI can take the friction out of life, but some effort can be good. *ScienceNews*. https://www.sciencenews.org/article/ai-removes-friction-effort-balance-good

SERVICE & TEACHING

Co-coordinator, Social Personality Research Group (SPRG) *2025–2026*

University of Toronto

- Organized weekly Social Psychology Department meetings for faculty and graduate students; coordinated logistics for invited external speakers.
- Redesigned departmental website including an auto-populating publications page.

Teaching Assistant — University of Toronto *2023–2026*

PSYC10: Judgment & Decision-Making | PSYB10: Intro to Social Psychology | PSYB70: Methods in Psychological Science | PSYC71: Social Psychology Lab | PSYC13: Social Cognition

- Delivered guest lecture on The Psychology of Nudges (Fall 2024, Winter 2026).

Chief Presiding Officer – Exam Invigilator *2024–Present*

University of Toronto

Orientation Coordinator — Psychology Graduate Students Association (PGSA) *2024–2025*

University of Toronto

- Planning events during recruitment and orientation week.

Social Media Coordinator — Psychology Graduate Students Association (PGSA) *2024–2025*

University of Toronto

- Update and redesign PGSA website

Event Coordinator — Canadian Psychology Association, Queen's University Branch *2022*

Queen's University

- Responsible for organizing, planning, and running CPA events at Queen's University
- Coordinating and communicating with outreach committee to raise awareness and engagement for CPA and CPA events

SKILLS & TRAINING

Data Sciences Institute Certificate – University of Toronto *2026–Present*

Unix Shell and Git | Python | SQL | Linear regression, classification, and resampling | Sampling | Visualization | Deploying AI

Research, Evaluation, and Data Analysis

R | JavaScript | jsPsych | Python | SQL | Git | Unix Shell | Qualtrics

- Independently clean, analyze, and visualize experimental and survey data using R.
- Apply regression-based methods, experimental designs, and causal inference principles to behavioural science research.
- Develop and program online behavioural experiments from scratch, including games, decision tasks, choice paradigms, and randomized study procedures using JavaScript and jsPsych.
- Manage study materials, datasets, documentation, and reproducible analysis workflows.
- Translate statistical findings into clear written summaries for research reports, presentations, and collaborative projects.

Design and UX

Wix |Squarespace | Notion | Canva | PowerPoint

- Skilled in creating engaging information presentations with Canva, Google Slides, and PowerPoint, tailoring designs for clarity and visual appeal.
- Experience in logo and web design, focusing on intuitive user experiences and consistent brand aesthetics.